‘Mucchu’ Chaudhuri. With the loss of NEFA and the threat to Assam, the prime minister knew that sooner or later there would be calls for his head. To keep the new man in check, Nehru decided to appoint Chaudhuri the ‘officiating chief’ who would continue to serve in his current rank, that of a lieutenant general. He was told to report at once to Delhi and take charge on 20 November. Though put out by the slight, Chaudhuri decided not to make an issue of it and agreed to operate as a three-star officiating Chief of Army Staff.

Second, by the evening of 19 November, the foreign secretary, M. J. Desai, and additional defence secretary, H. C. Sarin, were putting the final touches to a top secret letter from Prime Minister Nehru to the President of the United States, John F. Kennedy. Sarin had hinted that the government was contemplating asking the USAF and the RAF to come to India’s aid when he spoke to Palit the previous evening. In the latter half of the day, the DMO, along with Joint Secretary (Air) John Lall, was summoned to Sarin’s office. Without any preamble, the additional defence secretary handed over the draft of the letter and asked Palit and Lall for their comments, especially to confirm if the demand for the number of aircraft was adequate.

Nehru, the architect of India’s non-aligned policy, was openly asking for the intervention and active participation of the United States and Britain for the defence of India. As per the draft, Nehru was telling Kennedy ‘…the situation in NEFA Command has deteriorated still further. Bomdila has fallen and the retreating forces from Se-la have been trapped between the Se-la Ridge and Bomdila. A serious threat has developed to our Digboi oilfields in Assam. With the advance of the Chinese in massive strength, the entire Brahmaputra Valley is seriously threatened and unless something is done immediately to stem the tide, the whole of Assam, Tripura, Manipur and Nagaland would also pass into Chinese hands.

‘The Chinese have poised massive forces in the Chumbi Valley between Sikkim and Bhutan and another invasion from that direction appears imminent... In Ladakh, Chushul is under heavy attack and the shelling of the airfield at Chushul has already commenced. We have also noticed increasing air activity by the Chinese Air Force.’

After pointing out that hitherto India had ‘restricted our requests to essential equipment’ [most likely a reference to an earlier communication dated 29 October 1962] and thanking the US for the assistance ‘so readily given’, the draft went on: ‘We did not ask for more comprehensive